Unit 11: Those Winter Sundays (Poem)

Complete exercise solutions — all textbook questions answered (full book, 14 units)

Reading and Critical Thinking — Exercise A (Answers)

Q1. What do you think is Robert Hayden's attitude towards the father's sacrifices in the poem?

• Hayden's attitude is one of deep respect and regret. He presents the father as a silent, selfless worker whose love is shown entirely through actions — getting up early, lighting the fire, polishing shoes — and never through words.

• The line "No one ever thanked him" shows that the poet recognises the sacrifice was unacknowledged.

• The closing question, "What did I know, what did I know / of love's austere and lonely offices?" reveals the poet's mature understanding. He now sees that his father's plain, lonely duties were expressions of love, and he honours them with the poem itself.

Q2. How does the speaker's viewpoint change from childhood to adulthood? Support your answer with evidence from the text.

• As a child, the speaker is indifferent and fearful. He wakes to the cold "splintering, breaking," rises slowly, and speaks "indifferently" to his father. He fears "the chronic angers of that house" and does not thank his father.

• As an adult, the speaker looks back with regret and understanding. The repeated "What did I know, what did I know" shows that he now recognises his father's actions as love.

• The change is from ignorance to realisation. The child saw only a cold, angry house; the adult sees a father who "drove out the cold" with his own hands.

Q3. Do you think the poet is critical of his younger self? Why or why not?

• Yes, the poet is critical of his younger self, but gently and with regret rather than anger. He criticises his indifference: "Speaking indifferently to him" and "No one ever thanked him."

• The repetition of "What did I know, what did I know" is a self-reproach. He asks why he did not understand that the polished shoes and the warm rooms were love.

• However, the criticism is not bitter. The poet understands that a child cannot easily recognise love in such plain forms. The poem is an act of apology and gratitude.

Q4. How does Robert Hayden use imagery and symbolism to convey complex emotions in the poem?

• The image of the "blueblack cold" conveys a darkness that is both physical and emotional. The cold is not just weather; it is the emotional distance in the house.

• The "cracked hands that ached / from labor in the weekday weather" show the father's suffering through a single physical detail.

• The "banked fires blaze" symbolise the father's love and warmth. He literally drives out the cold, and the fire is his love made visible. The contrast between the cold outside and

the warm rooms inside mirrors the contrast between the father's silent love and the child's cold indifference.

Q5. Find an example of personification in the poem and explain its effect.

The cold is described as "splintering, breaking" — the cold is given the human-like action of breaking, as if it were a physical object that can snap. This personification makes the cold feel violent and alive, emphasising how harsh the winter mornings were and how much the father endured.

Q6. Why is the poem written in free verse? How does this enhance its meaning?

Free verse has no consistent rhyme scheme or meter, so it sounds like natural speech. This conversational style suits the poem's quiet, reflective tone — it feels like a memory being spoken aloud rather than a formal performance. The plain lines also mirror the plain, "austere" love of the father.

Q7. Explain the significance of the title "Those Winter Sundays." Why does the poet use the plural form "Sundays"?

• The plural "Sundays" shows that this was not a single morning but a repeated pattern — every Sunday, year after year, the father got up early in the cold. The sacrifice was routine, not occasional.

• "Winter" symbolises both the literal cold of the season and the emotional coldness between father and son.

• The title thus captures the whole theme: a long series of unnoticed sacrifices, repeated so often that they became invisible to the child.

Q8. Why does the speaker use the term "blueblack cold" to describe the winter morning?

• "Blueblack" is a compound colour word that suggests a darkness deeper than ordinary black — the darkness just before dawn, when the father got up.

• It makes the cold feel visual and heavy, almost a physical substance. The father dressed in this cold, which emphasises his endurance.

• The phrase also sets up the contrast with the warm rooms he created. The darker and colder the morning, the greater the father's sacrifice.

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Exercise B — Choose the Correct Option (Answer Key)

No.	Question	Answer
1	Who is the central figure in the poem besides the speaker?	c. the speaker's father
2	What time of day does the father wake up, and what does he do first?	c. early in the morning, to light the fire and warm the house
3	How does the speaker describe the father's hands?	c. cracked and aching from labour
4	What did the father do for the speaker that went unnoticed during childhood?	c. polished the speaker's shoes and warmed the house
5	What does the speaker mean by "chronic angers" in the house?	b. a long-lasting, tense atmosphere in the home

Exercise C — Inferences from Context (Answers)

• **1. "No one ever thanked him."** This suggests the father's efforts were taken for granted and unacknowledged. It adds to the tone of regret — the speaker now realises the ingratitude.

• **2. "Cracked hands that ached / from labor in the weekday weather."** The father had a hard, manual job that damaged his hands. The description suggests a life of physical suffering and poverty.

• **3. "I'd wake and hear the cold splintering, breaking."** The winter mornings were bitterly cold and harsh. The poet uses "splintering, breaking" to make the cold sound violent, as if it were snapping like wood.

Exercise D — Implied Meaning (Answers)

• **1. "Fearing the chronic angers of that house."** This implies the family's emotional environment was tense and cold. The anger was probably not directed only at the speaker; it was the general tension of a hard household.

• **2. "What did I know, what did I know / of love's austere and lonely offices?"** The speaker repeats the question to emphasise his regret. "Love's austere and lonely offices" suggests parental love is plain, dutiful, and performed alone without thanks.

• **3. The silence between father and son** suggests emotional distance. The father expresses love through work, and the son expresses nothing. The silence makes the poem more powerful because the reader feels the loneliness of a love that was never spoken.

Exercise E — Comparison with "Follower" by Seamus Heaney (Model)

Point	"Those Winter Sundays" (Hayden)	"Follower" (Heaney)
Theme	Unspoken parental love and regret	A son's admiration for his father's skill and work
Imagery	Cold, fire, cracked hands, polished shoes	Plough, horses, the father's strong back and shoulders
Tone	Reflective, regretful, quiet	Admiring, nostalgic, warm
Parent-child relationship	Distant and silent; love unrecognised in childhood	Close and admiring; the son follows the father's example

Vocabulary Exercises (Answers)

• **Dictionary information (model):** austere (adjective) — simple and plain; without decorations. blaze (verb/noun) — to burn brightly and strongly. chronic (adjective) — lasting a long time; difficult to solve. cracked (adjective) — damaged with lines in its surface. lonely (adjective) — where only a few people ever come or visit. office (noun) — a duty or service. splinter (verb) — to break into small sharp pieces. indifferently (adverb) — without interest or sympathy.

• **Synonyms (model):** austere — stern, severe; blaze — flame, flare; chronic — persistent, long-term; cracked — split, broken; lonely — solitary, isolated; splinter — shatter, fragment.

• **Sentences:** The austere room had no decorations. The fire blazed in the fireplace. He suffered from a chronic illness. The vase was cracked but still usable. The lonely house stood on the hill. The cold seemed to splinter the windows.

Grammar — Punctuation (Answers)

• a. We had a wonderful vacation in Skardu; it was a memorable experience. b. Some students prefer studying alone, but others enjoy group discussions. c. What time will you arrive at the airport tonight? d. Father had surgery; he had been feeling unwell for weeks. e. Can you tell me why she was so angry earlier?

Writing Tasks — Model Answers

A. Letter to the Father (as the adult speaker)

• **Opening:** "Dear Father, I am writing to you now, as an adult, to say what I could not say as a child: thank you."

• **Body:** Refer to the early mornings in the blueblack cold, the banked fires you made blaze with your cracked hands, and the good shoes you polished for me. "I spoke indifferently to you, and I never thanked you. I did not know then that your plain, lonely duties were love."

• **Closing:** "I cannot undo those winter Sundays, but I can honour them now. Your love was austere and lonely, but it was love, and I finally understand it. With gratitude and regret, your son."

B. Reflective Paragraph

• This poem changes my understanding of love because it shows that love is not always spoken. My own grandmother, for example, never said "I love you," but she woke before dawn to prepare my lunch and waited at the gate every evening. Like Hayden's father, her love was in her actions. The poem teaches me to recognise and thank the quiet sacrifices around me before it is too late.

C. Paraphrase of the Poem

• Every Sunday, my father got up early in the dark, cold morning and dressed. His hands were cracked and aching from hard labour, yet he lit the fires so the rooms would be warm. Nobody ever thanked him. I would wake and hear the cold cracking outside. When the rooms were warm, he called me, and I rose slowly, afraid of the tense atmosphere in the house. I spoke to him indifferently, even though he had driven out the cold and polished my shoes. Now, as an adult, I ask myself what I knew of love that is plain and lonely — love shown through duty rather than words.

D. Dialogue: Father, Mother, and Teenage Child

• **Setting:** [In the living room after dinner.]

• **Father:** [sighs] So, you have decided to take up music instead of medicine?

• **Child:** [nervously] Yes, Father. I have been practising for two years, and I have been selected for the youth orchestra.

• **Mother:** [smiling] Let him explain, dear. He has worked very hard for this.

• **Father:** [practically] Hard work is good, but can music feed a family? Medicine is a secure profession.

• **Child:** [eagerly] I know, Father, but I am not good at biology. In music, I can be excellent. Please give me a chance.

• **Mother:** [gently] We only want you to be happy and successful. If he works hard, he will succeed in music too.

• **Father:** [after a pause] Very well. But you must promise to practise every day and to keep your studies going.

• **Child:** [relieved] I promise, Father. Thank you!

E. Reference to Context

• **Lines:** "Speaking indifferently to him, / who had driven out the cold / and polished my good shoes as well. / What did I know, what did I know / of love's austere and lonely offices?"

• **Explanation:** The speaker, now an adult, regrets his indifference towards his father. The father had driven out the cold (lit the fires) and polished the speaker's shoes — acts of love performed in silence. The repeated question "What did I know" expresses regret for not understanding that "love's austere and lonely offices" — plain, lonely duties — were the father's way of loving. The lines sum up the poem's theme: true love can be silent, enduring, and unacknowledged.